What it Means to Be a Man – Collection 2

By Harold Norse; Guante (aka Kyle Tran Myhre) and Mark Gonzales

INTRODUCTION

Over the last three decades a lot of attention has been devoted to the question: "What does it mean to be a man?" These days, the media provides a range of contrasting images in answer to this question. For instance, there is the new domesticated and sensitive man, and his counterpart, the undomesticated, inarticulate and emotionally detached man. Or you may conclude as does Harold Norse . . . I am Not a Man.

I am Not a Man by Harold Norse (Pg 133)

I am not a man, I can't earn a living, buy things for my family.

I have acne and a small peter. *[edited to "small biceps"]*

I am not a man, I don't like football, boxing and cars.

I like to express my feelings,

and I even like to put an arm around my friends shoulders.

I am not a man, I won't play the role assigned to me.

4NG Fanatics

The role created by Madison Avenue, *Playboy*, Hollywood, and Oliver Cromwell. Television does not dictate my behavior.

I am not a man, once when I shot a squirrel I swore I would never kill again.

I gave up meat, the sight of blood makes me sick.

I like flowers.

I am not a man I went to prison for resisting the draft.

I do not fight back when real men beat me up or call me queer.

I dislike violence.

I am not a man, I have never raped a woman, I don't hate blacks.

I don't get emotional when a flag is waved.

I do not think I should love America or leave it, I think I should laugh at it.

I am not a man. I have never had the clap. *[edited: removed]*

I am not a man. *Playboy* is not my favorite magazine.

I am not a man. I cry when I am unhappy.

I am not a man. I do not feel superior to women.

I am not a man. I don't wear a jockstrap.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

I am not a man. I write poetry.

I am not a man. I meditate on peace and love.

I am not a man. I do not want to destroy you.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Harold Norse
Book: The Outlaw Bible of American Poetry, Pg 133
ISBN: 978-1560252276
Publisher: Thunder's Mouth Press
Date (Month/Year): Nov 1999

AWARD HISTORY

2004 National Qualifier – Norse Poem Only
2005 National Qualifier – Norse Poem Only
2009 National Qualifier – Norse Poem Only
2010 National Qualifier – Norse Poem Only
(Combined with Logic In the House of Sawed-Off Telescopes by Jeffrey McDaniel (Pg 253) and I'm an Emotional Idiot by Maggie Estep (Pg 256) -- The Outlaw Bible of American Poetry)

TRANSITION

In our society today, I can almost guarantee that you have heard one of the following phrases – "Be a Man" – "Boys don't cry" or the all-encompassing . . . "Man Up." And maybe, just maybe boys and men have wanted to respond with something other than straightening their spines and biting their lips. Responses to the Phrase "Man up" by Kyle "Guante" Tran Myhre

4NG Fanatics

Responses to the Phrase 'Man Up' (Pg 18-19) by Guante (aka Kyle Tran Myhre)

1. If you want to question my masculinity, save your breath. Because contrary to what you may believe, not every problem can be solved by "growing a pair." You can't arm-wrestle your way out of chemical depression. The CEO of the company that just laid you off does not care how much you [can] bench.
2. The phrase "Man Up" suggests that competence and perseverance are uniquely masculine traits. More than anything, though, it suggests that to be yourself—whether you wear skinny jeans, listen to Lady Gaga, rock a little eyeliner, or write poetry—will cost you.

3. How many boys have to kill themselves before this country acknowledges the problem? How many women have to be assaulted? How many trans people have to be murdered? We teach boys how to wear the skin of a man, but we also teach them how to raise that skin like a flag and draw blood for it.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

4. Boy babies get blue socks. Girl babies get pink socks. What about purple? What about orange, yellow, chartreuse, black, tie-dyed, rainbow . . .

5. I want to be free to express myself. Man up. I want to have meaningful, emotional relationships with my brothers. Man up. I want to be weak sometimes. Man up. I want to be strong in a way that isn't about physical power or dominance. Man up. I want to be who I am.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Kyle "Guante" Tran Myhre
Book: A Love Song, A Death Rattle, A Battle Cry, Pg 18-19)
ISBN: 978-1943735334
Publisher: Button Poetry
Date (Month/Year): February 2018

TRANSITION

Consider the "idea" of what it has meant to be a man in our society. Many are quick to assume that to be a man means being aggressive, loud, violent, and dominant. But today I want to celebrate men who are trying to redefine what it means to be one. As with Most Men by Mark Gonzales

4NG Fanatics

As with Most Men by Mark Gonzales (Book 8)

As with most men, it is easier for me to give hugs than to accept them.

At the age of five
men are taught to colonize one another
through games like cops and robbers
cowboys and Indians.

At the age of eight
we're given helmets
then told to hit each other in the head with [them].
Bleed but do not blink
cut but do not cry.

Be a man, join the military
die for your country
and if death comes for you
look it in the eye, say
'bring it on, I fear nothing but
intimacy.'

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

When it comes to intimacy
men quiver like fault
lines, crumble like cities

Men take note:
this is how you give love
this is how you receive hugs
pressed breast to breast
till egos deflate like oxygen.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Mark Gonzales
Book: Critical Muslim (Book 8)
ISBN: 978-1849043175
Publisher: Hurst Publishers
Date (Month/Year): September 2014

TRANSITION

And still hugs between men are often full of bravado, back slapping and crushing power which expels every bit of air from one's lungs. Why? Why must a sign of affection be turned into a show of power. "Guante" explores this concept in Handshakes.

4NG Fanatics

Handshakes by Guante (aka Kyle Tran Myhre) (Pg 20-21)

As a young man, I was taught that one's masculinity is tied directly to one's handshake. Your grip must be firm. Some men, however, treat every handshake like a gladiator's death-match, a test of strength, a test of will.
And when I meet these men, as I often do, their handshakes never fail to illuminate my inadequacies. I am reminded that cars confuse and frighten me and that I don't really care about sports. These men attempt to squeeze the testosterone from my body.

Maybe I'm just insecure. But maybe that would make two of us. As he wrings the color from my fingers I find myself wanting to ask him:

Do you ever get tired of the voice in your head telling you to constantly reaffirm that you're a "real man" by catcalling women, eating enormous hamburgers, and squeezing everything really, really hard?

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

Is there a teddy bear, somewhere in your history, being ripped away from a pair of hands that just aren't strong enough?

Do you remember the first time your father wouldn't let you hold his hand when crossing the street? Do you remember the way he looked at you?

Do you remember being handed your first-born son and not knowing how to hold him? Do you remember squeezing his shoulders like this the first time he disappointed you?

Do you remember what you were trying to hold on to?

And I know: there is so much space between us, as men, that sometimes we feel compelled to cram as much contact as we physically can into every touch. I know.

We've become so comfortable with crushing, so hypnotized by our own strength, we forget: how incredible it can feel to let go.

4NG Fanatics

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Kyle "Guante" Tran Myhre
Book: A Love Song, A Death Rattle, A Battle Cry, Pg 20-21
ISBN: 978-1943735334
Publisher: Button Poetry
Date (Month/Year): February 2018

AWARD HISTORY

2021 National Qualifier – MS – As a Collection
KS State Qualifier – As a Collection
NOTE:
Poem by Norse was not included in KS State Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY